AVÈRO ADVISORS

TEMPLATE 02

START AT ZERO TOOLKIT · TEMPLATE 02

Three-Layer RACI Matrix

Who decides what across your agency, the software vendor, the system integrator and an independent PMO, from Phase Zero through benefits realization.

Most failed implementations had plenty of people. What they lacked was clarity about who decides. The three-layer model separates the parties whose interests differ: the **software vendor** licenses the product, the **system integrator** configures and deploys it, and an **independent PMO** with no financial tie to either protects the agency. The agency keeps every decision that matters.

> **Key.** R = Responsible (does the work) · A = Accountable (approves, one per row) · C = Consulted (gives input before) · I = Informed (told after) · -= no role

Activity	Exec Sponsor	Steering Cmte	Agency Project Team	Independent PMO	Software Vendor	System Integrator
PHASE ZERO AND PROCUREMENT						
Approve project charter and governance structure	**A**	R	C	C	-	-
Define business requirements	I	**A**	R	R	-	-
Draft RFP and evaluation criteria	**A**	C	C	R	-	-
Run scripted scenario demonstrations	I	**A**	R	R	R	C
Check references (beyond the vendor's list)	I	**A**	C	R	C	C
Evaluate and score proposals	**A**	C	R	R	-	-
Recommend and award vendor and integrator	**A**	R	C	C	-	-
Negotiate contract terms	**A**	I	R	C	C	C
IMPLEMENTATION						
Maintain the integrated project plan	I	I	**A**	C	C	R
Configure and build the system	I	I	**A**	C	C	R
Submit a change order	I	I	**A**	C	R	R
Approve a change order	**A**	C	C	R	I	I
Data conversion and reconciliation	I	I	**A**	C	C	R
Integration build and testing	I	I	**A**	C	C	R
User acceptance testing	I	I	R	**A**	C	R
Training and change management	I	I	**A**	C	C	R
Status reporting to the steering committee	**A**	I	C	R	I	C

Activity	Exec Sponsor	Steering Cmte	Agency Project Team	Independent PMO	Software Vendor	System Integrator
Escalate risks and issues	I	**A**	R	R	C	C
GO-LIVE AND AFTER						
Go/No-Go decision	**A**	C	C	R	C	C
Cutover execution	I	I	**A**	C	C	R
Post go-live support and stabilization	I	I	**A**	C	R	R
Accept final deliverables and release payment holdback	**A**	I	R	C	I	I
Track benefits realization	**A**	I	R	C	-	-
NAMED LEAD						

Rules of the road

- **One A per row.** Two accountable parties means none.
- **The vendor and the integrator are never Accountable.** A party paid by the outcome of a decision should not approve it.
- **The PMO reports to the Executive Sponsor,** not to IT and never to the integrator.
- **Whoever requests a change order does not approve it.**
- **Name a person under every column** before kickoff and sign this page with the governance charter.
- **Revisit at every phase gate.** Roles drift as pressure rises.

Red flags

- The same firm appears in two columns, or your advisor has a partnership with the vendor or integrator.
- Vendor or integrator staff hold voting seats on the steering committee.
- Status reports are written by the party whose performance they describe.
- "We'll sort out roles after kickoff."

Birmingham's project board had the people implementing the system evaluating their own progress. This matrix exists so that never happens in your agency.

From *Start at Zero: Leading High-Stakes Modernization in the Age of AI* by Abhijit Verekar. Free to use and adapt inside your agency. © 2026 Avero Advisors. More at startatzero.averoadvisors.com and avavero.substack.com.